

A Comparative Study on Imagery Use among State level Middle Distance Freestyle and Individual Medley Male Swimmers

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ABSTRACT

The purpose of the present study was to analyze imagery use among state level middle distance freestyle and individual medley male swimmers. The sample consisted of sixty (N=60) subjects who have participated in state level competition. Out of the total 60, there were 30 swimmers each of middle-distance freestyle and individual medley events. The age range of the subjects was between 15 to 25 years. After the sample selection consent was taken from all the participants to participate in the study. Sports imagery scale was administered to all the participants. The Data were collected from mostly all region of the India. Data collection was done during the state level competition such as Senior state, junior state championship. There was no significant difference in 4 out of 5 dimensions of imagery use i.e., Cognitive Specific, Cognitive General, Motivation Specific and Motivation General Mastery. However, there was a significant difference on one of the dimensions i.e., Motivation General Arousal. The implications and future directions are discussed further.

INTRODUCTION

Sport psychology is an exciting field that is growing all the time, and in a grueling sport such as swimming enhancing the mental aspect of a swimmer's arsenal is crucial to success. At its most basic, swim psychology is about streamlining your life and your mind by getting rid of that which hinders your swimming (creates drag) and striving to do only that which helps your swimming. All of the athletes are talented, most of them are physically gifted and all of the athletes have devoted

all of their time to training. Moreover, all of the athletes are the very best within their sport. The difference between medaling and falling short will come down to the mental game. Many athletes have turned to the power of imagery to give themselves an edge over the competition.

Simoes, et. al. (2012) studied the impact of the implementation of a mental training program on swimmers' chronometric performance, with national and international Portuguese swimmers,

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based on the goal setting model proposed by Vasconcelos-Raposo (2001). This longitudinal study comprised a sample of nine swimmers (four male and five female) aged between fourteen and twenty, with five to eleven years of competitive experience. All swimmers were submitted to an evaluation system during two years. The first season involved the implementation of the goal setting model, and the second season was only evaluation, totaling seven assessments over the two years. The main results showed a significant improvement in chronometric performance during psychological intervention, followed by a reduction in swimmers' performance in the second season, when there was no interference from the investigator.

Post, et. al., (2012) examined the influence of an imagery intervention on the performance of swimmers' times on a thousand-yard practice set. Performance times for four swimmers were collected over a 15-week period during preseason training. The intervention took place over a 3-week period and was introduced after the fourth week of the study. The results revealed that three out of four participants significantly improved their times on the thousand yards practice set after being introduced to the imagery intervention. The results are discussed in terms of the implications of using imagery to improve athlete's performance on continuous task.

Imagery is one of the greatest tools used in sports psychology to enhance

performance. Studies have found that practicing imagery, along with regular training, enhances muscle memory and sports skills faster and further than regular training alone. In a competitive world where only, the slightest improvement can be the difference between a champion and a runner-up, we need to take all the opportunities that we can to become elite at what we do.

Present study is trying to find out the level of imagery use among swimmers. Imagery is a powerful technique which athlete develops as a skill and he/she can be trained further for imagery use with the help of experts to help them to enhance the performance and minimizing the negative effect of over training.

METHOD

Design

It was a Survey Study focused on comparison of use of imagery among state level middle distance freestyle and individual medley male swimmers.

Sample

The sample consists of sixty (N=60) subjects who have participated in state level competition. The purpose of the present study was to analyze imagery use among state level middle distance freestyle and individual medley male swimmers. Out of the total 60, there were 30 swimmers each of middle-distance freestyle and individual medley events. The age range of the subjects was between 15 to 25 years. Subjects selected

for the study were only male swimmers.

Tools

1. Socio-demographic Data Sheet: A Socio-demographic Questionnaire was prepared for the purpose of the present study containing items related to Socio-demographic details i.e., age, education, gender etc. of the participants. Apart from this, the questionnaire was also containing items related to sport specific parameters i.e., swimming event, swimming distance, training experience etc.

2. Sports Imagery Questionnaire (SIQ; Hall et al., 1998): This questionnaire assesses the frequency of athletes' imagery. Each of the SIQ's 30 items represents one of the five imagery functions i.e., Cognitive Specific, Cognitive General, Motivation Specific, Motivation General Mastery and Motivation General Arousal.

Procedure: After the sample selection consent was taken from all the participants to participate in the study. Sports imagery scale was administered to all the participants. The Data were collected from mostly all region of the

India. Most of the Data collected during the state level competition such as Senior state, junior state championship. Further, the data were tabulated and analyzed using Statistical Package for Social Sciences (SPSS) Software.

Statistical Approach:

1. The Data obtained were compiled and statistically analyzed with the help of SPSS software.
2. In the order to match the sample, the Socio-demographic details were analyzed using the chi-square Test and the t-Test.

RESULTS

Table 1 shows the age and experience distribution of the sample concerning the two study groups. The mean age of participants was 19.70 ± 2.98 for the Individual medley group and 19.16 ± 2.97 for the middle-distance Freestyle group. The t-value (.694) and sign. Value. (.491) was statistically insignificant and shows that there was no significant difference among the age distribution of participants.

Table-1: Comparison of Age and Training Experience between the groups

Variable	Groups		t	Sig.
	Individual Medley M $\pm$ S. D	Middle Distance Freestyle M $\pm$ S. D		
AGE	19.70 $\pm$ 2.98	19.16 $\pm$ 2.97	.694	.491
Training Experience	7.23 $\pm$ 3.26	6.23 $\pm$ 3.43	1.156	.252

** Significant at 0.01 level

* Significant at 0.05 level

Similarly, the mean game experience of participants was 7.23 ± 3.26 for the Individual medley group and 6.23 ± 3.43 for the middle-distance Freestyle group. The t-value (1.156) and sign. Value (.252) was statistically insignificant and shows that there was no significant difference among the game experience distribution of participants.

Table 2 shows the researcher found there was no significant difference in 4 out of 5 sub-variables of imagery use i.e., Cognitive Specific, Cognitive General, Motivation Specific and Motivation General Mastery.

Table 2: Imagery Use between the groups

Variable	Groups		Mean Square	t	Sig.
	Individual Medley M $\pm$ S. D	Middle Distance Freestyle M $\pm$ S. D			
Cognitive Specific	30.43 $\pm$ 6.60	32.30 $\pm$ 06.31	52.267	-1.119	.268
Cognitive General	30.06 $\pm$ 5.58	32.36 $\pm$ 4.96	79.350	-1.686	.097
Motivation Specific	33.70 $\pm$ 7.70	34.73 $\pm$ 4.73	16.017	-0.626	.534
Motivation General Arousal	27.30 $\pm$ 6.52	31.53 $\pm$ 5.97	268.817	-2.621	.011*
Motivation General Mastery	34.53 $\pm$ 4.38	35.86 $\pm$ 4.99	26.667	-1.099	.276

** Significant at 0.01 level

* Significant at 0.05 level

The obtained "t-value" for the above 04 - variables (Cognitive Specific, Cognitive General, Motivation Specific and Motivation General Mastery) which are not found to be statistically significant. The researcher found a significant difference in one variable i.e., Motivation General Arousal. Obtained "t-value" shows that which are found to be statistically significant. We also cannot ignore the t-value and Sig. value of Cognitive General which seems to be nearly statistically significant.

CONCLUSION

The present study was conducted to know the level of imagery use among middle distance freestyle swimmers and individual medley swimmers. The study hypothesized that there would be a significant difference and relationship among psychological factors among swimmers. For the purpose of matching the sample socio-demographic status example of age, and training experience were analyzed. The study shows the age characteristics of individual medley and

Middle-distance freestyle swimmers. There is no significant difference found among the age of swimmers. Some other confounding variables might have been there but the effort was made to keep them under control by keeping the conditions of testing the same for the entire subject.

The result of the study on imagery indicates that imagery training is beneficial and a very effective technique for the psychological preparation of swimmers. In this particular study, the researcher studied the effect of imagery training on certain psychological variables. Examples:- 1. Cognitive Specific, 2. Cognitive General, 3. Motivation Specific and

4. Motivation General Mastery
5. Motivation General Arousal.

There was no significant difference in 4 out of 5 variables of imagery use i.e., Cognitive Specific, Cognitive General, Motivation Specific and Motivation General Mastery. However, there was a significant difference on one of the variables i.e., Motivation General Arousal.

It is the further part of study why motivation General Arousal variable found to be statistically significant. We also cannot ignore to the t-value and Sig. value of Cognitive General variable as it seems to be nearly statistically significant.

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